

A list of some of the best summer programs for high school students covering science, technology, engineering, mathematics, biomedical sciences, business, journalism, creative writing, the arts, law, and the social sciences. The programs can be filtered on the basis of cost, type, and eligibility to suit your interests.

Personal Experience: Research programs allowed me to pursue subjects that I found truly interesting and undertake projects beyond the scope of a regular class assignment. It was amazing for me to be able to learn under the guidance of mentors who taught me the process of conducting actual research by posing questions, gathering data, and analyzing outcomes. Despite the difficulty of the task, it gave me satisfaction and confidence to solve the problems on my own. These experiences allowed me to see that high school is not only a stage when you study more advanced material but also an opportunity to find new interests and useful skills.

Program Name	Field	Cost	Format	Eligibility	quick description
MIT Beaver Works Summer Institute (BWSI)	Engineering, AI, Robotics	Free	Virtual with optional in-person capstone	Open to all students	Hands-on engineering challenges such as autonomous vehicles, drones, and AI systems.
Stanford SHTeM	Interdisciplinary STEM	Free	Virtual	Open to all students	Remote Stanford lab research blending science, technology, engineering, and math.
Simons Summer Research Program	STEM	Free	In-person	U.S. citizens and permanent residents	Highly selective university lab placement with real research experience.
Garcia Summer Research Program	Polymer Science, Bioengineering	Free for selected scholars	In-person	Open to all students	Deep wet-lab exposure with advanced techniques and publishable work.
Boston University RISE	STEM	Free for selected students	In-person	Open to all students	Students work on real research projects in BU labs with strong mentorship.
NIH HS-SIP	Biomedical and Computational Research	Free	In-person	U.S. citizens and permanent residents	Prestigious federal internship with advanced lab exposure.
National Cancer Institute Internships	Cancer Research	Free	In-person	U.S. citizens and permanent residents	Students work with scientists studying cancer biology and treatments.
eCLOSE Institute	Cancer and Diabetes Research	Free	Virtual	Open to all students	Students run real experiments using fruit flies and analyze biological data.

Horizon Academic Research Program	Multiple fields	Free for scholarship recipients	Virtual	Open to all students	Students produce academic papers with mentor guidance.
UPenn LSM Summer Program	Life Sciences and Business	Free	Virtual	Open to all students	Blends biology with entrepreneurship and biotech innovation.
Rosetta Institute Workshops	Molecular Biology, Medical Research	Free for scholarship recipients	Virtual and In-person	Open to all students	Teaches fundamentals of molecular biology through hands-on labs.
Yale Young Scholars Research Program	Interdisciplinary Research	Free for scholarship recipients	Virtual	Open to all students	Structured introduction to research across STEM and humanities.
Harvard HSSP Research Program	Social Science and STEM	Free	Virtual	Open to all students	Beginner-friendly program teaching foundational research skills.
NASA SEES	Space Science, Earth Science	Free	Virtual with in-person component	U.S. citizens and permanent residents	Students work with NASA scientists and real NASA data.
Rockefeller SSRP	Biomedical Research	Free	In-person	Open to all students	Students join labs studying genetics, cell biology, and neuroscience.
Jackson Laboratory Program	Genetics, Biomedical Research	Free	In-person	U.S. citizens and permanent residents	Students work on genetics and disease research.
Cold Spring Harbor DNA Learning Center	Genetics, Molecular Biology	Free for selected students	In-person	Open to all students	Hands-on DNA and genomics training.
UCSF High School Internships	Biomedical and Clinical Research	Free	In-person	U.S. citizens and permanent residents	Students join UCSF labs studying diseases and treatments.
Broad Institute SRP	Genomics, Computational Biology	Free	In-person	U.S. citizens and permanent residents	Students work on cutting-edge genomics projects.
Fred Hutch Internship	Cancer Research	Free	In-person	U.S. citizens and permanent residents	Students learn lab techniques and work on cancer research projects.
Research Science Institute (RSI)	STEM Research	Free	In-person	Open to all students	Highly selective program pairing students with top research mentors for original research.
Girls Who Code Summer Immersion	Computer Science	Free	Virtual and In-person	Open to girls and nonbinary students	Intensive coding program teaching web development, robotics, and app design.

Summer Science Program (SSP)	Astrophysics, Biochemistry	Paid, need-based aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Students conduct original research in astrophysics or biochemistry at partner campuses.
MITES (MIT)	STEM	Free	In-person	U.S. citizens and permanent residents	Rigorous six-week academic program for underrepresented students in STEM.
Clark Scholars Program	STEM Research	Free, stipend provided	In-person	U.S. high school juniors	Seven-week individualized research experience at Texas Tech University.
Notre Dame STEM Camps	STEM	Free for selected students	In-person	Open to all students	Discipline-specific STEM camps in engineering, chemistry, and physics.
Telluride Association Summer Seminar (TASS)	Humanities and STEM	Free	In-person	Open to all students	Intensive seminar-style program in critical thinking, writing, and research.
Cornell Summer College	Multiple fields	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Pre-college program offering college-level coursework across many disciplines.
Johns Hopkins CTY Summer Programs	Multiple fields	Paid, financial aid available	In-person and Virtual	Open to qualifying students	Accelerated academic courses for gifted students across STEM and humanities.
Duke TIP Summer Studies	Multiple fields	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to qualifying students	Academically intensive residential courses for gifted middle and high schoolers.
Stanford AI4ALL	Artificial Intelligence	Free	In-person	Open to underrepresented students	Introduces students to AI concepts, ethics, and applications through mentorship.
Michigan MMSS (Math and Science Scholars)	Math and Science	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	College-level math and science coursework taught by University of Michigan faculty.
Carnegie Mellon SAMS	STEM	Free	In-person	Open to underrepresented/first-gen students	Pre-college program exposing students to engineering and computer science.
Iowa State YESS (Young Entomologists)	Entomology, Biology	Free	In-person	Open to all students	Research-based program studying insect biology and ecology.
Anson L. Clark Scholars	STEM Research	Free, stipend provided	In-person	U.S. high school juniors	Individual research mentorship program at Texas Tech University.

Kean University Summer Research Academy	STEM	Free	In-person	New Jersey residents	Lab-based research experience for high school students.
Columbia Science Honors Program	STEM	Free	In-person	NYC-area students	Saturday science and math courses taught by Columbia faculty and researchers.
Brown University Pre-College Programs	Multiple fields	Paid, financial aid available	In-person and Virtual	Open to all students	College-level courses across STEM, humanities, and social sciences.
UC Berkeley COSMOS	STEM	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	California residents preferred	Cluster-based STEM research program with UC Berkeley faculty.
Georgia Tech Aerospace Engineering Camps	Aerospace Engineering	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Hands-on engineering camps focused on aerospace design and flight.
Purdue Summer STEM Camps	STEM	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Discipline-based STEM camps including robotics, coding, and engineering.
University of Michigan MSPE Camps	Engineering	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Engineering-focused residential camps introducing multiple engineering disciplines.
Emory PREP Program	Biomedical Research	Free	In-person	Georgia residents preferred	Pipeline research program for underrepresented students in biomedical sciences.
Wake Forest Summer Immersion	STEM and Humanities	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	College-level immersion courses across a wide range of subjects.
Rutgers Science Explorer Camps	STEM	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Hands-on STEM exploration camps for middle and high schoolers.
Penn State Engineering Summer Academy	Engineering	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Introductory engineering design program with hands-on projects.
University of Chicago RIBS (Research in the Biological Sciences)	Biological Sciences	Free	In-person	Chicago-area students preferred	Wet-lab based research introduction for high school students.

Case Western SUES Program	Engineering	Free for selected students	In-person	Open to all students	Summer engineering experience for underrepresented students.
Arizona State University SPARKS	STEM	Free	Virtual and In-person	Open to all students	Introductory STEM research and career exploration program.
Vanderbilt Aspinaut Program	STEM	Free	In-person	Rural and underserved students	Hands-on STEM research pipeline program for underserved communities.
University of Washington SPURS	Biomedical Research	Free	In-person	Washington state residents preferred	Summer research program pairing students with biomedical research labs.
Iowa Young Writers' Studio	Creative Writing	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Intensive fiction, poetry, and creative nonfiction workshop at the University of Iowa.
Kenyon Review Young Writers	Creative Writing	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Workshop-based program developing literary craft with published authors.
Medill-Northwestern Journalism Institute	Journalism	Paid, scholarships available	In-person	Open to all students	Hands-on journalism training including reporting, writing, and multimedia storytelling.
Columbia Journalism for High School Students	Journalism	Paid	In-person and Virtual	Open to all students	Introduces reporting, editing, and media ethics through real assignments.
Yale Summer Session — Global Affairs	International Relations	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	College-level coursework in diplomacy, policy, and global affairs.
Georgetown Diplomacy Institute	International Relations, Diplomacy	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Simulates diplomatic negotiation and explores global policy issues.
National Student Leadership Conference (Law)	Law and Politics	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Mock trial and legal reasoning program introducing the U.S. legal system.
Harvard Pre-College Program	Multiple fields (Humanities/Business/Law)	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Two-week academic exploration across humanities, business, and pre-law tracks.
Wharton Global Youth Program	Business and Entrepreneurship	Paid, financial aid available	In-person and Virtual	Open to all students	Introduces business fundamentals, finance, and entrepreneurship through case studies.

NYU Stern Precollege Business Program	Business	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	College-level business coursework in finance, marketing, and management.
LaunchX Entrepreneurship Program	Entrepreneurship	Paid, scholarships available	In-person and Virtual	Open to all students	Students build and pitch a real startup with mentorship from entrepreneurs.
Sotheby's Institute Young Artists Program	Art History, Museum Studies	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Explores art history, curation, and the art market through museum visits.
RISD Pre-College Program	Studio Art and Design	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Intensive studio art and design program taught by RISD faculty.
Parsons Summer Intensive Studies	Fashion and Design	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Hands-on courses in fashion design, illustration, and visual arts.
Interlochen Arts Camp	Performing and Visual Arts	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Immersive arts camp covering music, theater, dance, and visual arts.
Berklee Summer Performance Program	Music	Paid, scholarships available	In-person	Open to all students	Performance-focused music program covering songwriting, production, and ensembles.
National High School Institute (Cherubs) — Theatre	Theatre and Performing Arts	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Northwestern's rigorous theatre and performance training program.
Boston University Film and TV Institute	Film and Media Production	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Hands-on filmmaking program covering screenwriting, production, and editing.
NYU Tisch Future Filmmakers Workshop	Film Production	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Introductory filmmaking workshop culminating in a completed short film.
USC Summer Media and Journalism Workshop	Media and Communications	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Explores journalism, media production, and digital storytelling.
Telluride Association Sophomore Seminar (TASP)	Social Sciences and Humanities	Free	In-present	Open to all students	College-level seminar in social and political thought for rising juniors.

National Student Leadership Conference (Psychology)	Psychology	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Introduces psychology research methods, neuroscience, and clinical applications.
Boston University Summer Journalism Academy	Journalism	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Reporting-focused academy for aspiring student journalists.
Model United Nations Institute (Harvard)	Political Science, Diplomacy	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Simulated UN negotiations building diplomacy and public speaking skills.
American University Discover the World of Communication	Communications	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Explores journalism, PR, and political communication in Washington D.C.
Fashion Institute of Technology Pre-College	Fashion and Design	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Studio-based fashion design and merchandising courses.
Juilliard Summer Programs	Music and Dance	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Elite performance training in classical music, jazz, and dance.
Debate and Public Speaking Institute (Stanford)	Debate, Public Speaking	Paid, scholarships available	In-person	Open to all students	Competitive debate and rhetoric training with college coaches.
Culinary Institute of America Summer Program	Culinary Arts	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Hands-on culinary training covering technique, nutrition, and food science.
Sarah Lawrence Writers' Camp	Creative Writing	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Workshop-based writing camp emphasizing voice and craft development.
Cornell Cooperative Extension 4-H Summer Programs	Agriculture, Environmental Science	Free or low-cost	In-person	Open to all students	Hands-on agricultural science and sustainability programs.
Global Youth Institute (World Food Prize)	Agriculture, Global Studies	Free	In-person	Open to all students	Research-based program addressing global food security challenges.
Yale Bulldogs Summer in Economics	Economics	Paid, financial	In-person	Open to all students	Introduces micro/macroeconomics

		aid available			through case studies and market simulations.
Notre Dame Ethics Bowl Summer Institute	Philosophy, Ethics	Paid, scholarships available	In-person	Open to all students	Explores applied ethics and moral reasoning through structured debate.
Boston University Summer in Public Health	Public Health	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Explores epidemiology, health policy, and community health interventions.
Cornell Architecture Summer Program	Architecture	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Studio-based design program teaching architectural drafting and modeling.
University of Virginia Young Writers Workshop	Creative Writing	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Small-group writing workshop for poetry and fiction.
National Student Leadership Conference (Sports Medicine)	Sports Science, Medicine	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Hands-on exploration of athletic training, biomechanics, and sports medicine.
Smithsonian Youth Engagement Through Science	Anthropology, Museum Studies	Free for selected students	In-person	Open to all students	Museum-based program exploring anthropology and natural history research.
University of Pennsylvania Summer Linguistics Institute	Linguistics	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Introduces language structure, phonetics, and computational linguistics.
Teach for America Summer Leadership Academy	Education, Social Justice	Free for selected students	In-person	Open to all students	Explores education equity and community leadership through service projects.
Environmental Leadership Program (Various Universities)	Environmental Science, Policy	Free or low-cost	In-person	Open to all students	Field-based program studying conservation, sustainability, and climate policy.
Georgetown Institute for Global Health	Global Health	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Examines global health disparities and international health policy.
Barnard Pre-College Program —	Gender Studies, Leadership	Paid, financial aid available	In-person	Open to all students	Explores gender studies, leadership, and social advocacy.

Women's Leadership					
National Student Leadership Conference (Forensic Science)	Forensic Science	Paid	In-person	Open to all students	Hands-on crime scene analysis and forensic lab techniques.
Princeton Summer Journal of Philosophy	Philosophy	Free for selected students	Virtual	Open to all students	Students write and workshop original philosophical papers with mentors.